Quest 1: "Get the Wizard Back to Work!"

Beneath the Questline: revised design document

Rank: Bronze **Posted by:** Crowned King's Ministry **Location:** Far too east of Crystalham **Reward:** To be defined (suggestion: 15 Silver from the Ministry, plus a bonus depending on the outcome)



> *"The Ministry has received no satisfactory explanation for the wizard's prolonged absence. Several knights were dispatched to retrieve him, but abandoned the assignment after making little progress through the tower. They complained of exhaustion, hunger, and the unreasonable amount of time required to reach the upper floors.*
>
> *The wizard is expected to resume his royal duties immediately.*
>
> *Additional note: the wizard has reportedly been conducting research into an unusual field of magical study. Adventurers are advised to exercise caution when navigating his tower."*

Objective: Reach the wizard's quarters at the top of the tower, confront him, and escort him back to the King.

The contract is marked **low risk**. The Ministry is wrong about that, and about almost everything else in it.

1. Design Pillars

The quest rests on three ideas that feed each other:

1. **The tower is a puzzle you read, not a place you climb.** There are no stairs. Every room connects to the next through spatially altered gates, so progress means reading gate numbers and colors and choosing the right exit.
2. **You are never fighting, only managing fear.** Zinnia hunts through the Fear Index. The player survives through route knowledge, safe zones, and calm, not combat.
3. **The quest brief is a lie the player slowly unlearns.** The wizard is not a lazy recluse. The tower is not a maze built for fun. Zinnia is not a simple monster.



GATES BETWEEN ROOMS

Tension source: Spatial disorientation (the knights gave up from exhaustion, not from wounds), the sense that the tower is *bigger on the inside than any route should allow*, and a small, fast, frightened creature that is always somewhere behind the next gate.

2. Pacing & Tension Curve

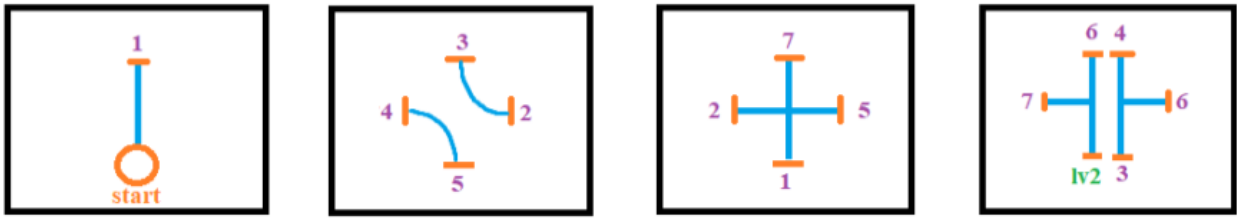
Act 1: The Road and the First Gate (Level 1, Normal World)

Tone: Dry, bureaucratic, mildly comedic.

- The player receives the contract and travels east of Crystalham.
- A couple of NPCs on the road mention the knights who came back hungry, sunburned in odd places, and unwilling to talk.
- The tower looks wrong from outside: windows at impossible heights, balconies attached to nothing.
- Level 1 is a linear corridor: **start > gate 1**. The player walks through, and the world quietly turns inside out.

Tension goal: Curiosity and a small laugh. The player thinks this is an escort job.

1st level:



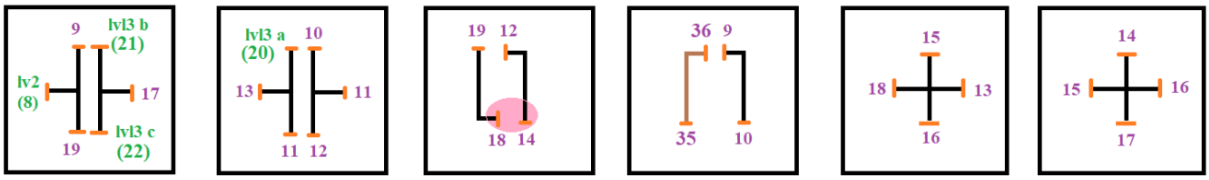
Act 2: Learning the Gates (Levels 1 to 2, Rising Unease)

Tone: Puzzled, then uneasy.

- Rooms start to offer several gates (curved passages, crossroads, double corridors). The player learns that **the gate you enter by is not the gate you leave by**, and that numbered gates link to other numbered gates.
- Notes, pinned diagrams, and abandoned experiments appear. Everything supports the *Absent Wizard* reading (Layer I).
- Level 2 introduces **dead ends and loops** (rooms where every path leads back).
- Fear Index sits in the **Calm range (0 to 25)**. Zinnia is only a sound or a shape at the edge of vision.

Tension goal: Intellectual engagement and the first real fear of being lost.

2nd level:



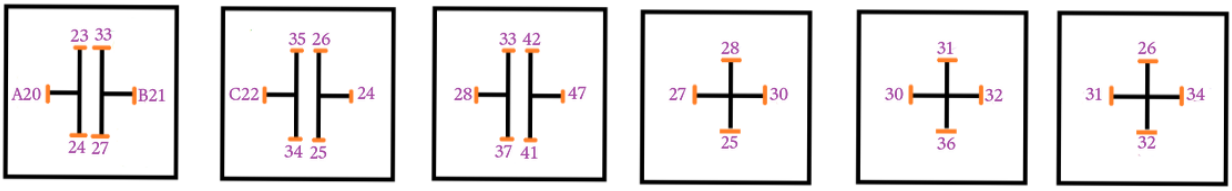
Act 3: The First Safe Zone and the Artifact (Level 3, Point of No Return)

Tone: Relief, then wonder.

- Deep in Level 3 the player finds **Safe Zone 1** (gate 23): a small, quiet, lit room where Zinnia cannot enter.
- Here the player obtains the **Artifact** (see section 5).
- The first time the player rotates it, a gate **changes to its second color** and opens a path that did not exist before.
- This is the moment the player understands the tower has *two* layouts layered over each other.

Tension goal: Reward and empowerment, right before it is taken away. From here on, Zinnia hunts actively.

3rd level:



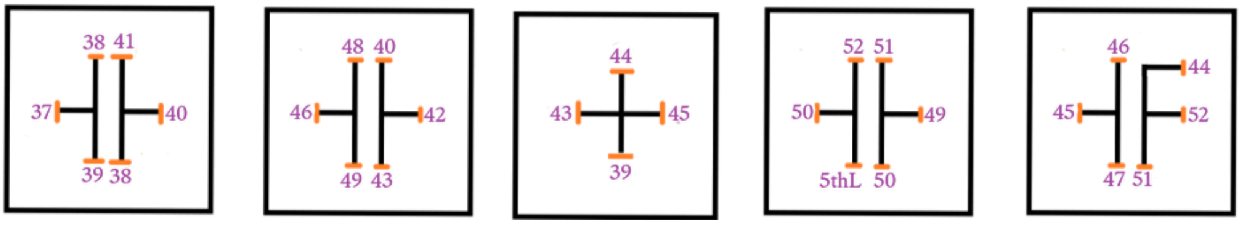
Act 4: Being Hunted (Levels 4 to 5, Horror Escalation)

Tone: Pressure and dread.

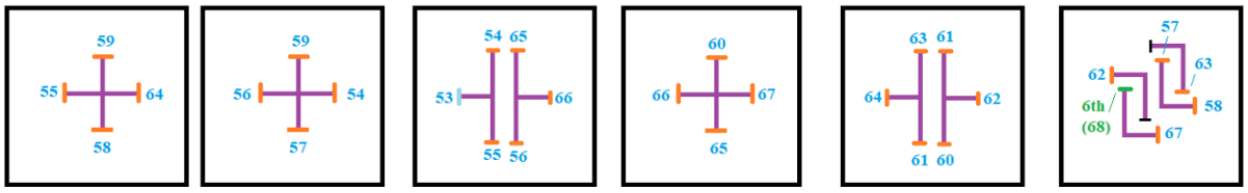
- Zinnia moves from observing to stalking as the Fear Index passes 25 and 50.
- Rooms get denser: more gates per room, more wrong exits. Level 5's rooms are the most tangled and use purple and blue gates, which only appear in some states of the artifact.
- **Safe Zone 2** (gate 48) can only be reached with the artifact in its second state. It is the player's mid-level breather, and a test of whether they remember the route.
- Environmental storytelling intensifies: a half-finished second desk, two sets of handwriting in the notes, a woman's coat hanging in a hallway, a ring of chalk in front of a gate that has been scratched out.

Tension goal: Fear turns into active danger. The player now knows two people lived here.

4th level:



5th Level:



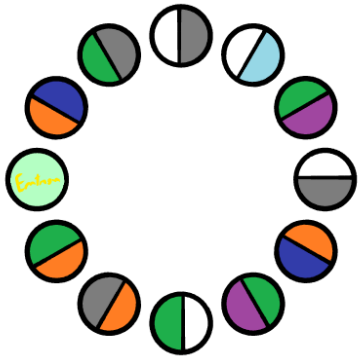
Act 5: The Ring and the Office (Level 6, Climax)

Tone: Grief, awe, and cornered desperation.

- Level 6 is a single circular chamber with **12 two-colored gates** arranged in a ring. Only one leads to the wizard's quarters/Office, and which one depends on the **color state** the player has set with the artifact.
- Zinnia is at her most aggressive here, because the ring is the nearest thing to home she has seen in years.
- Beyond the right gate(light blue connection): the wizard's office, the confrontation, and the truth.

Tension goal: High panic, then a sudden emotional drop when the player finally meets him.

6th Level:



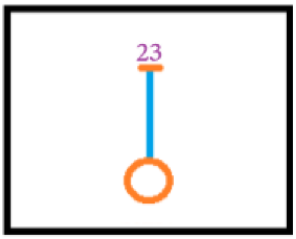
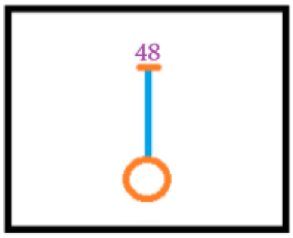
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3. Locations

The Tower (exterior): A crooked stone spire with wooden rooms bolted to its sides, balconies and extensions sprouting at odd angles. It looks like it grew rather than was built. Visible only briefly: after Level 1, the exterior no longer matters.

Gate rooms (Levels 1 to 5): Short, modular corridor and crossroads rooms with numbered archways. Level 1 has 4 rooms, Levels 2, 3 and 5 have 6, Level 4 has 5. Rooms are built from a small set of reusable pieces: straight, curve, crossroads, double corridor, L-turn.

Safe Zones: Small lit chambers with a single archway. They are calm and warm, and they are the only places Zinnia cannot enter. Recovery here is the strongest in the game.

1st Safe Zone: in Level 3	
2nd Safe Zone: (with the artifact) in Level 4	

The Ring Chamber (Level 6): A round room with twelve gates in a circle, each split into two colors. Cold light, no furniture, no sound beyond a faint hum.

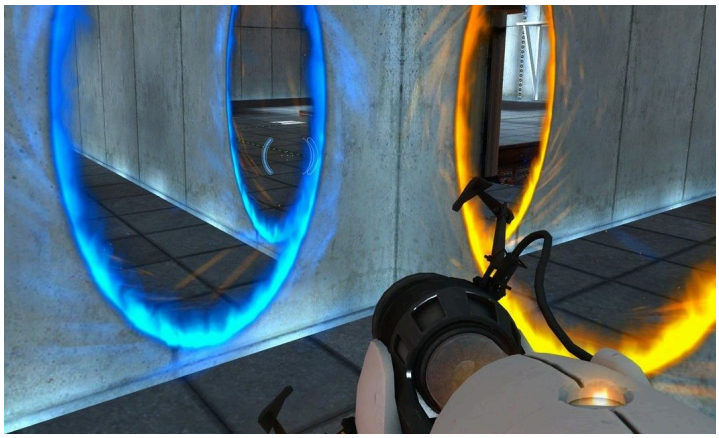
The Wizard's Office: Scholar's clutter turned into a prison. Telescope, astrolabe, shelves, a half-collapsed portal frame glowing blue-purple. Two desks, one of them untouched. A single set of dishes, kept clean on purpose.



On Sketchfab, I actually did a prototype of what the [Wizard's Office would look like; here is the Link]

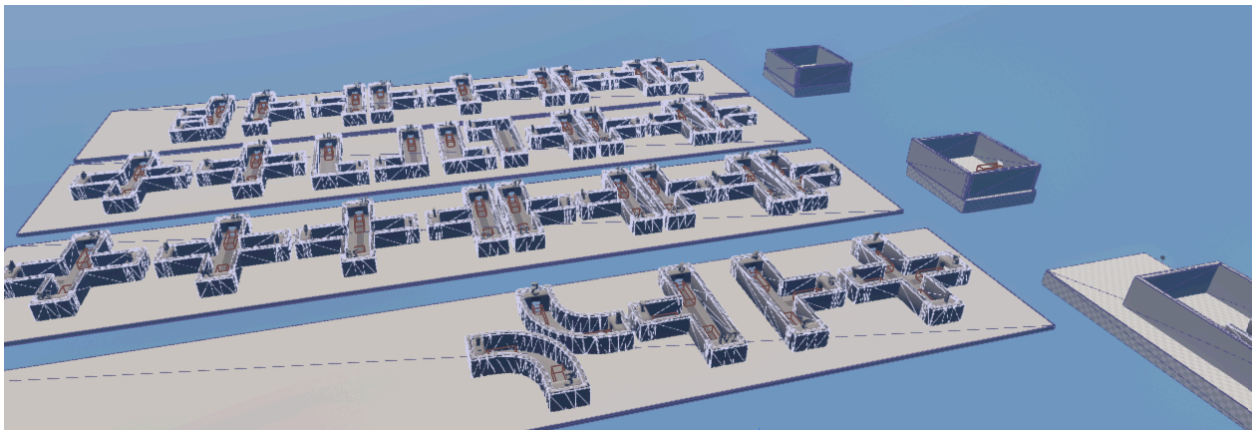
4. Core Mechanic: The Gates

4.1 Rules



1. Every gate has a **number** and a **color(in case of the last level)**. Entering gate N places the player in the room paired with N.
2. Most gates have a **second color**: a second destination. Without the artifact, only the first state is active.
3. Rotating the artifact flips the **targeted gate** to its second state. It does not flip the whole tower, only the gate the player is facing.
4. Safe Zones are the only places where the Fear Index drops reliably.
5. Zinnia **can follow through gates**, but with a short delay.
6. Gate states **reset when the player leaves the room**, so the player cannot permanently rewrite the tower.

Progress so far:



4.2 Level Summary

Level	Rooms	Role	New idea
1	4	Tutorial	Walking through a gate. Learning that exits are not where you expect.
2	6	Orientation	Dead ends, loops, and the first double corridors.
3	6	Exploration	Safe Zone 1 (gate 23). The artifact is obtained.

Level	Rooms	Role	New idea
4	5	Pressure	Zinnia stalks. Safe Zone 2 (gate 48) requires the artifact.
5	6	Mastery	Dense, tangled rooms. Purple and blue gates. Zinnia blocks paths.
6	12 gates	Climax	The ring: pick the right gate in the right color.

4.3 Anti-frustration rules

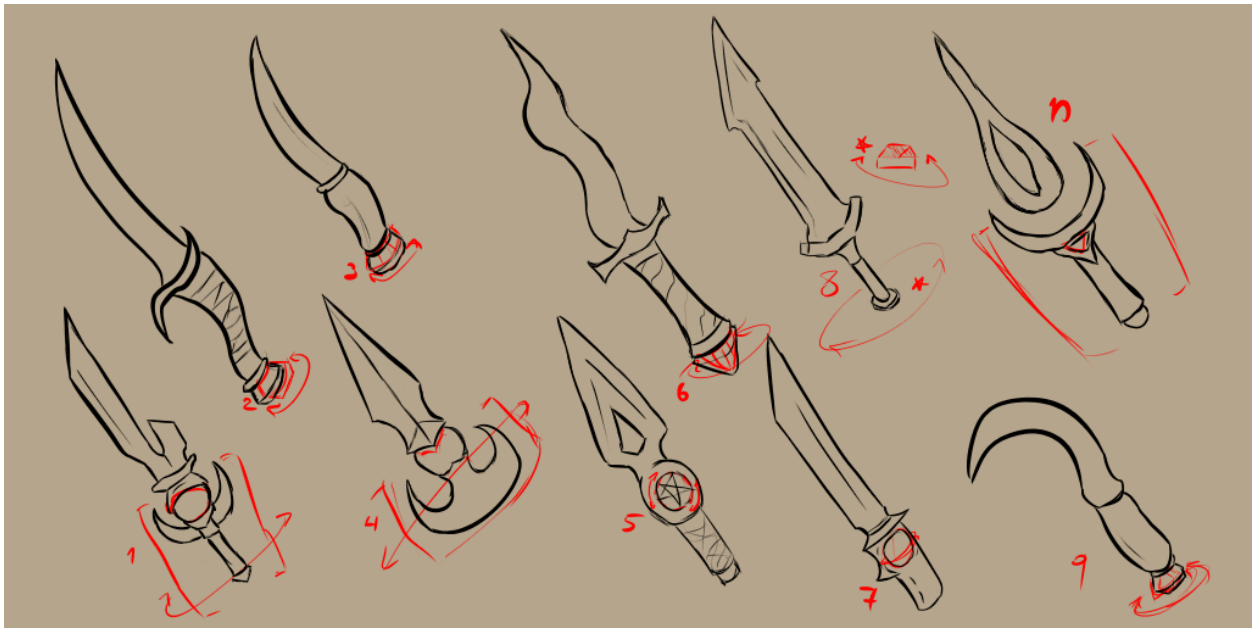
- Dead ends always contain either a clue, a collectible note, or a hiding spot, never nothing.
- Making sure it's necessary:
    - Gate numbers are painted on arches (WIP making sure it's necessary), so the player can keep a mental map or write notes.
    - If the player has looped the same room three times, a subtle chalk mark appears pointing toward the correct exit (a sign the *wife's handwriting* is still in the tower).

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5. The Artifact

5.1 What it is

A ritual blade used as a **dimensional key**. It was made by the wizard and his spouse to anchor a gate in place. It is the only reason the tower has two layouts instead of one. It is **not a weapon**, and the game never lets the player attack with it.



Design Ideas for the Artifact

5.2 Rotation concepts

The concept sheet shows ten dagger and blade silhouettes, each with a red marker for the part that rotates. All of them rotate a pommel, a crescent guard, or a seal around the hilt.

#	Rotating part	Read at a glance	Notes
1	Ring and crescent guard	Strong	Ring clearly reads as a dial.
2	Pommel ring	Medium	Elegant, but small.
3	Pommel	Medium	Simple, hard to read in first person.
4	Wide crescent guard	Strong	Large silhouette, distinctive.
5	Round seal with star on guard	Very strong	The star can glow when active.
6	Pommel gem	Strong	Gem can show the current gate color.
7	Guard ring	Medium	Closest to a standard sword.
8	Pommel plus a tiny gate icon	Strong	Icon shows the gate state.

#	Rotating part	Read at a glance	Notes
9	Sickle pommel	Weak	Reads more like a farm tool.
10	Big crescent plus gem	Strong	Memorable shape.

Recommendation: Prototype **#5** (round star seal) or **#6** (gem that shows the target color) first. Both give clear visual feedback on which state the gate will take, without a HUD.

5.3 Use animation (first person)

A short, readable sequence, around 1.5 seconds:

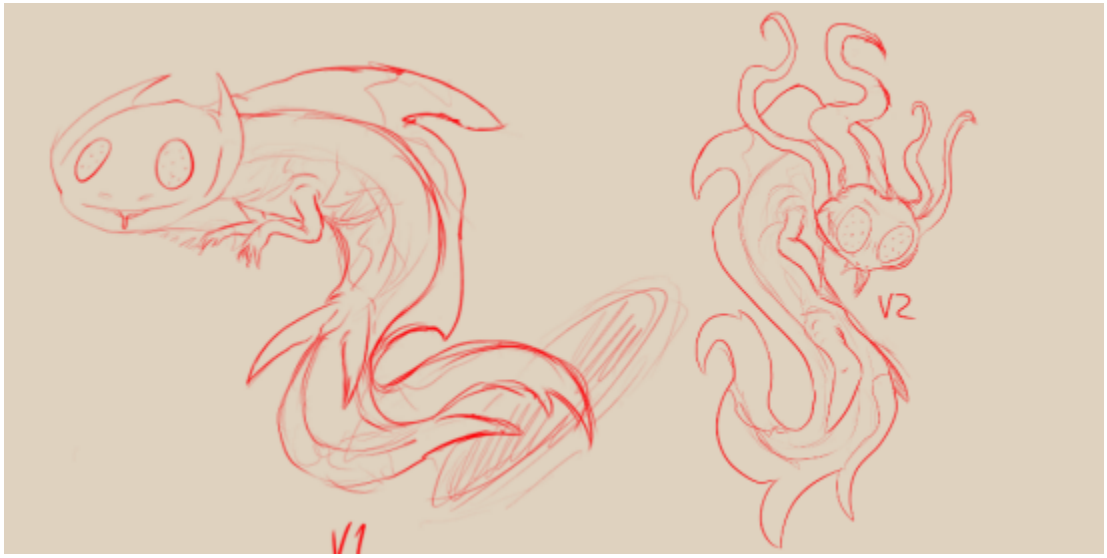
1. **Raise:** the player lifts the artifact toward the gate with one hand.
2. **Grip:** the other hand grabs the rotating part.
3. **Rotate:** a quarter or half turn, with a soft click and a hum.
4. **Flash:** the artifact glows in the gate's new color; the gate flickers and swaps.
5. **Lower:** hands return to neutral.

Design rules:

- The animation is **a vulnerability window**. It cannot be cancelled, so using it near Zinnia is a risk.
- It makes a small sound (+5 Fear Index as a suggested starting value), so it competes with the player's need to stay quiet.
- It glows, which counts as a light source.

6. Enemy Behavior: Zinnia

Appearance (from the storyboard): A dog-sized creature with a pink crystalline body, long fins and tendrils, and teal eyes. Fast, agile, and clearly not from this world.



First Concepts

True nature: Zinnia is **not purely hostile**. She saw an opportunity to leave her dimension in the rupture and escaped through with the wizard. She doesn't want to return to the hellish place where she came with the unknown god. She hunts the royal guard, the adventurers, or anything that might disturb the wizard, for she is thankful to be in this dimension.

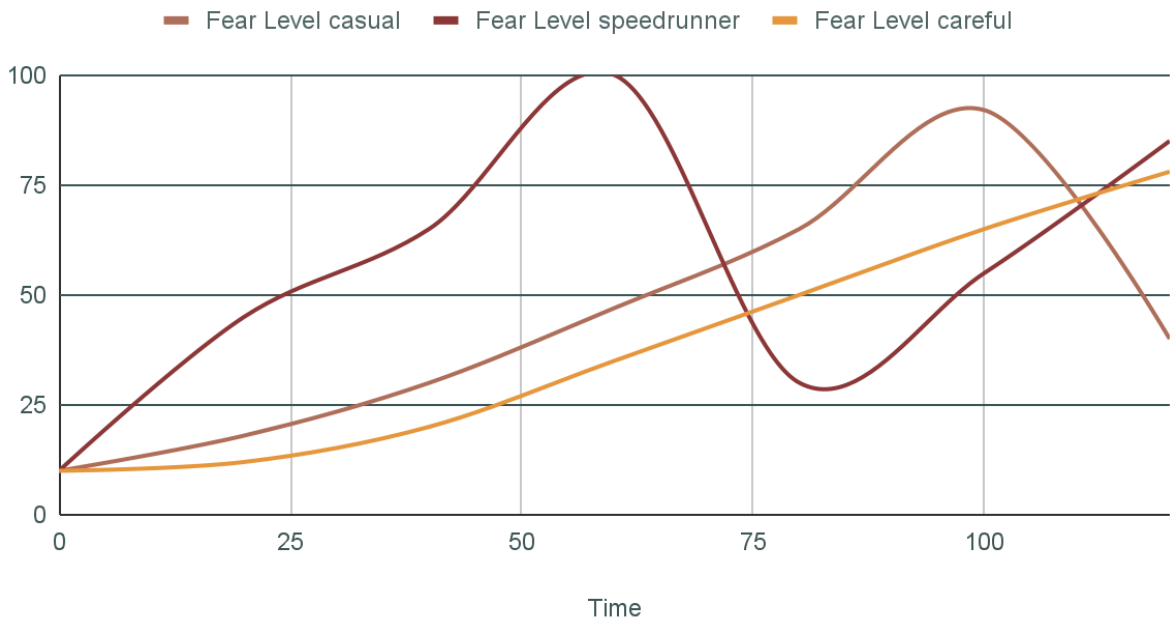
Design: Zinnia “never” kills, that is, directly. A capture ends in a short stagger and a reset to the last safe point, not a game-over. Her threat is lost progress and lost time, which is exactly what the knights complained about.

But she can use traps and open dimension rifts to make the player lose track ot even die.

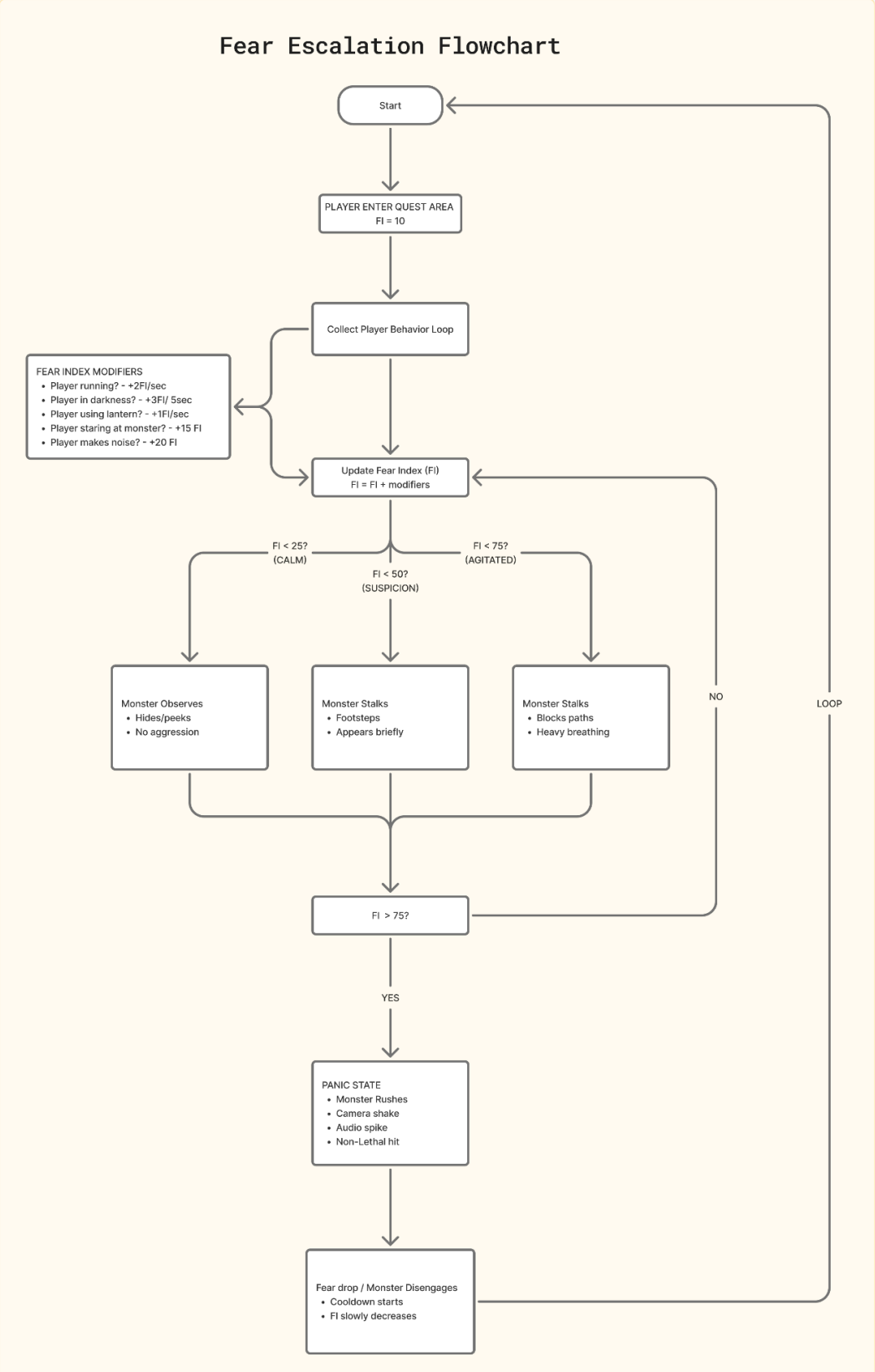
Fear Escalation Curve Overview

Range	Player Behavior Trigger	Monster Behavior	Environmental Effects	Audio Cues	Notes
0 to 25	Walking, normal light use	Observes from afar	Normal lighting	Soft ambience	Setup phase
25 to 50	Running, long darkness	Stalking begins	Slight flickers	Distant footsteps	Raises tension
50 to 75	Noise, loud actions	Closer stalking, blocking paths	Shadow movement	Whispering	Player feels hunted
75 to 100	Sprinting, staring directly at the monster	Rushes player (non-lethal)	Major flickers	Loud spike	Climax moment

Fear Index Table



Player > System > Escalation Flow

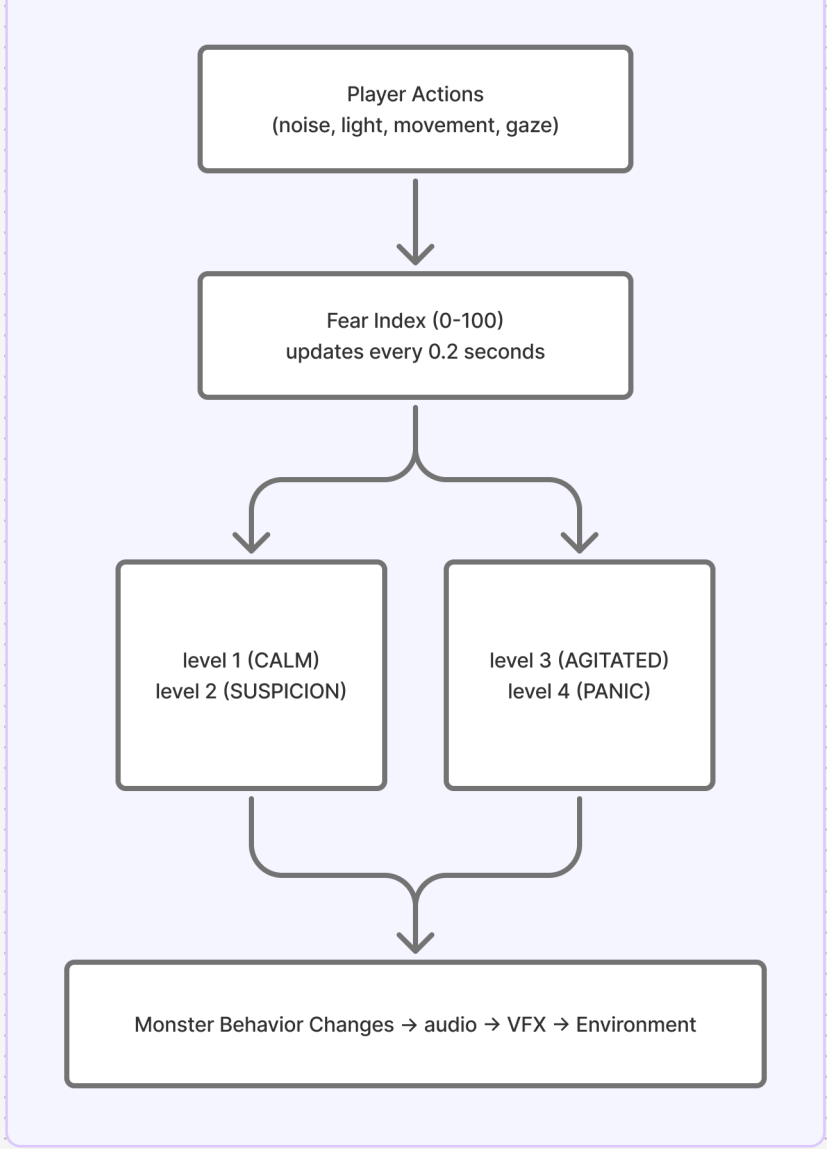


Player Action Fear Values

Player Action	FI Added	Duration	Notes
Walk	0	Continuous	Safe movement
Run	2/sec	While running	Makes tension rise
Uses a light source	1/sec	While shining	Attracts monster interest
Stay in dark	3 every 5 sec	Timer-based	Fear of unknown
Look at monster	15 every 3 sec	Timer-based	Very effective
Make loud noise	20	One-time	Jump in escalation

Inspiration: Alien Isolation tracked detection risk

Monster Behavior Design



6.1 Fear Index (FI) states

The existing Fear Index system stays as the engine (0 to 100, updated every 0.2 seconds).

State	FI	Zinnia	Environment	Audio
Calm	0 to 25	Observes from afar, hides and peeks	Normal lighting	Soft ambience
Suspicion	25 to 50	Brief appearances, partial silhouettes	Slight flickers	Distant footsteps, skittering
Agitated	50 to 75	Blocks paths, glowing eyes	Shadow movement	Whispering, chiming
Panic	75 to 100	Rushes the player (non-lethal)	Major flickers	Loud spike

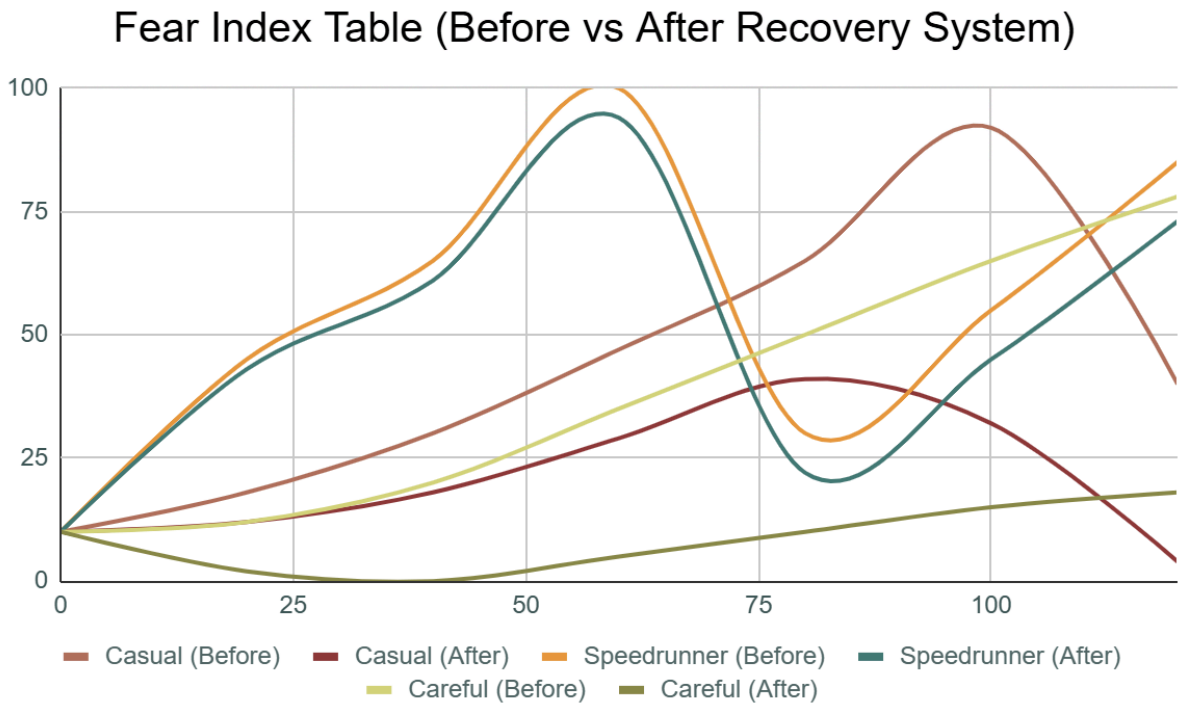
Behavior is adaptive and context-aware, meaning the Monster can dynamically choose strategies based on player actions, increasing replayability and emergent fear scenarios.

Scenario Example:

Player runs in darkness > Fear rises to 60 > Monster blocks the corridor > Player hides in a crate > Fear drops > Monster retreats

Fear Index (FI) Recovery

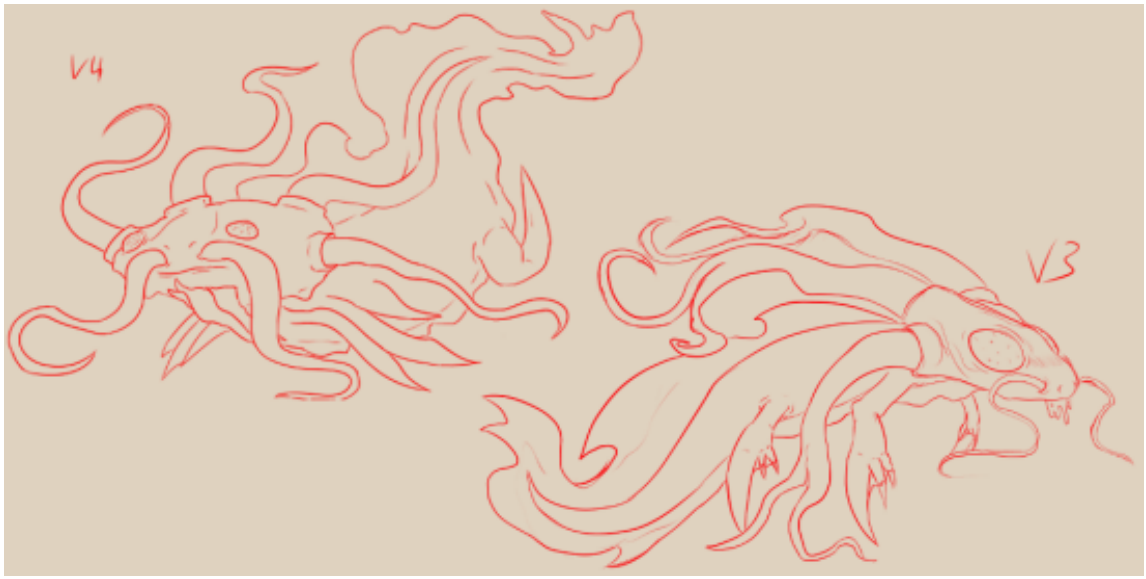
Player Action / Condition	FI Change	Type	Notes
Safe light (bright area)	−1/sec	Passive	Only if walking or standing still
Hiding successfully	−15	Conditional	Reset mechanic
Staying silent	−5 every 10 sec	Conditional	No running, no noise
Safe zone	−3/sec	Environmental	Monster cannot enter



6.2 New: Zinnia and the gates

These rules tie the monster to the main mechanic:

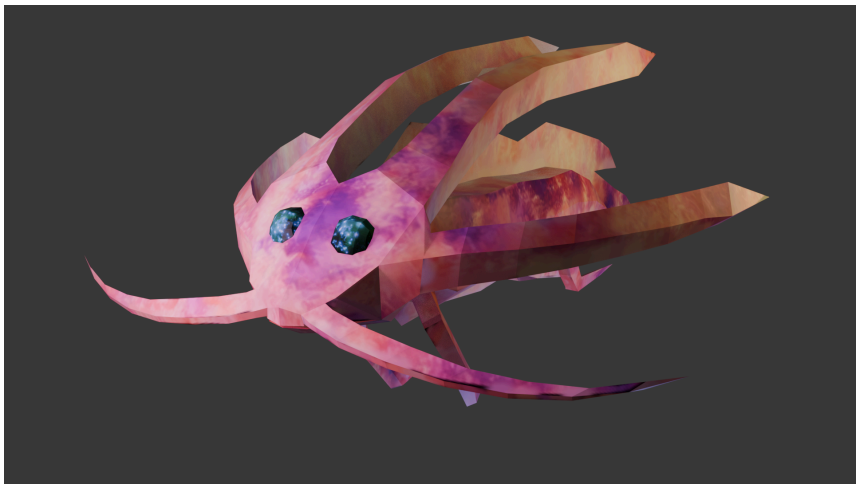
- **Gate pursuit:** Zinnia follows through gates with a 3 to 5 second delay. Taking several gates quickly buys distance.
- **Gate blocking:** At 50+ FI, she can sit in front of a gate, forcing the player to find another route or flip it to its second color.
- **Artifact attraction:** When the player rotates the artifact, Zinnia hears it. Using the artifact repeatedly is a controlled risk.
- **Safe Zones:** She cannot enter. Standing at the arch, she stares in, and the glow in her eyes dims.
- **Retreat:** After a Panic rush, she retreats for 20 to 30 seconds, and the FI drops slowly, creating the peaks and valleys the system is designed for.



Second Concepts

6.3 Reveal across the quest

1. **Level 2:** a sound, a shadow, a gate that was open now closed.
2. **Level 3:** first full silhouette at a distance. She flinches away when the player lifts the artifact.
3. **Level 4 to 5:** close encounters. She is clearly frightened, not furious.
4. **Level 6:** she does not attack at the ring. She stops and looks at the artifact.



PS1 Style Render

This system turns fear into a living mechanic. By combining escalation with recovery, the Fear Index creates natural peaks and dips that keep players tense without overwhelming them.

Each playstyle produces its own curve, making the Monster feel adaptive and alive. Instead of linear pacing, the game now breathes, building suspense, releasing pressure, and tightening again. This foundation sets the stage for reactive horror encounters that stay engaging from start to finish.

Link To Sketchfab

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7. The Wizard



7.1 Character

The Crown's court wizard, now middle-aged to elderly, who has spent years searching for a way to reopen the passage and bring his spouse home. He did not abandon his duties; he stopped being able to do anything else.

Personality: Exhausted, short-tempered, defensive. Treats the player as an interruption. Underneath, he is desperate for someone to say he is not crazy.

7.2 Visual design (PS1 model)

Base: the low-poly concept (grey swept-back hair, thick grey beard, round glasses, brown shoulder mantle, cream robe with dark hem pattern, belt with pouches and a book, brown boots). Then push the character toward **worn down, angry, and neglected**:

- **Face:** Deep under-eye bags, hollow cheeks, permanent scowl, one eyebrow raised in irritation.
- **Glasses:** Cracked lens, bent frame, taped hinge. One lens smudged.
- **Hair and beard:** Greasy, matted, uneven. Beard with stains and burn marks. Strands stuck out.
- **Robe:** Wrinkled, singed edges, ink and food stains, patched knees, dull colors compared to the clean concept.
- **Belt:** Overstuffed with crumpled notes, loose pages sticking out, an unlatched pouch.
- **Hands:** Ink-stained fingers, chewed nails.
- **Posture:** Slouched, shoulders heavy, leaning on furniture.
- **Keep the small cross pin** from the portrait, as a link to his old life.

PS1 production notes:

- Around 400 to 800 triangles.
- A single 64x64 or 128x128 texture, with the grime painted into it (no extra geometry).
- Flat shading, vertex snapping, and affine texture warping for authenticity.
- Use the stains as storytelling: ink on the right sleeve (writing hand), scorch marks on the left (failed experiments).

7.3 The spouse Olara



Shown in the AI-generated portrait: long, wavy silver-grey hair, blue-grey garments, a pendant, a calm smile. She appears:

- In a **framed portrait** in the office (the pixel-art piece).
- In **memory flashes** from the storyboard (the experiment, the rupture, the loss).
- Through **traces**: her coat in the hallway, a second desk, her handwriting in the notes.

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8. The Truth Behind the Quest

The player should never get the whole story at once.

Layer I: The Absent Wizard (Levels 1 to 2). *What the player believes:* he is a recluse obsessed with his work. Evidence: abandoned experiments, odd portals, scribbled formulas.

Layer II: The Failed Experiment (Levels 3 to 4). *What the player suspects:* the tower's architecture is dimensional manipulation. Notes mention research done *with someone else*. Something happened here.

Layer III: The Thing That Came Back (Levels 5 to 6). *What the player discovers:* the wizard escaped a dimensional rupture, but his spouse did not. Zinnia crossed over with him. His research has become an attempt to reopen the passage and rescue her. His absence was grief turned into an obsession.

Environmental clues per level:

Level	Clue
1	A cheerful calendar, last page torn out years ago.
2	Two cups on a desk, one clean and one stained.
3	A second set of handwriting in the margins.
4	A woman's coat, a hairpin, a comb.
5	A diagram with a person drawn at the edge of the gate, circled and underlined.
6	The ring itself: eleven gates are wrong, one is a promise.

9. Quest Flow

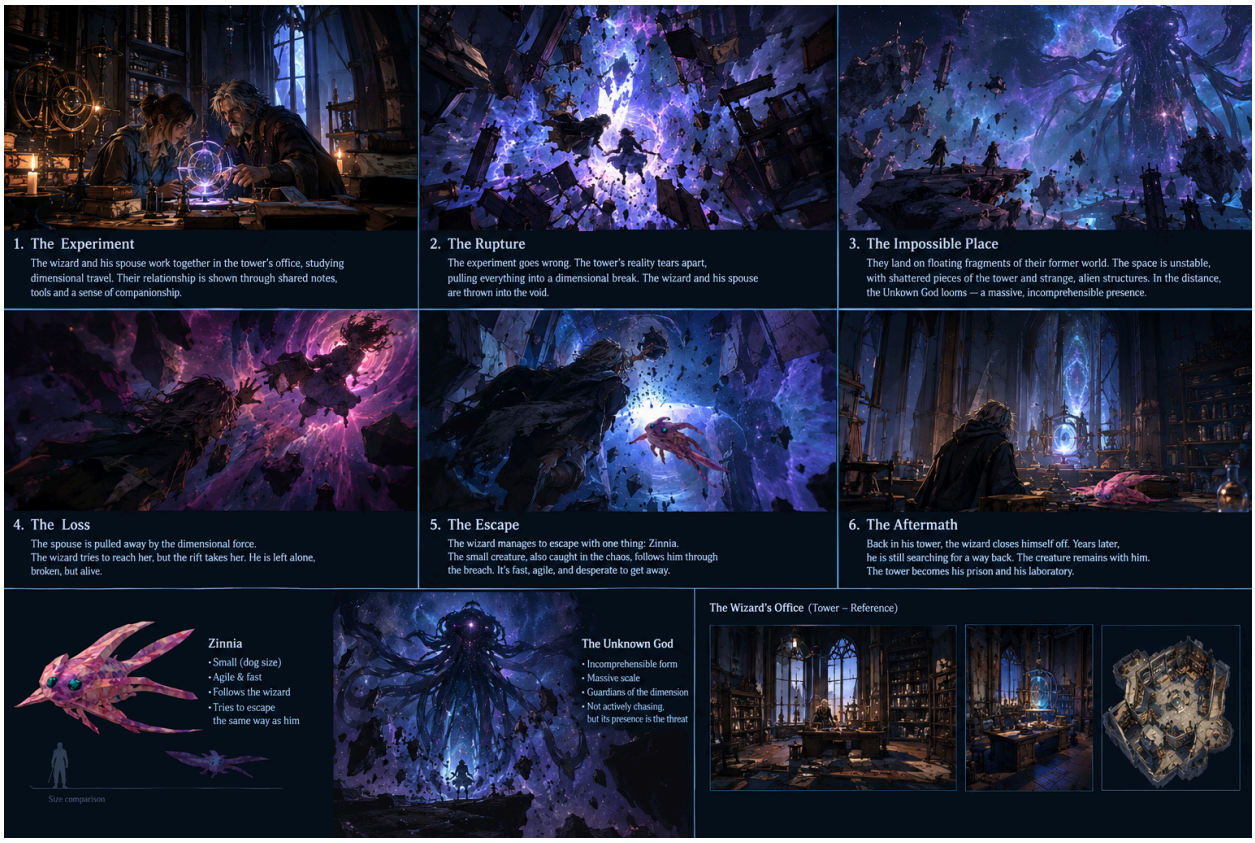
Accept contract > Travel east of Crystalham > Enter the tower (Level 1) > Learn the gates (Levels 1 to 2) > Safe Zone 1 and the artifact (Level 3) > Hunted through Levels 4 and 5 > Safe Zone 2 (gate 48) > The ring (Level 6) > Meet the wizard > **Player choice** > Outcome.

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10. Player Choice

Players hear the wizard's side in a small cinematic when the player enters the wizard’s Office. As the player continues to pick the correct combination in the dimension orb, the wizard responds with a small cough and tells the tale of why he will not go back until his work is done…

The origin of Zinnia and why the wizard is holed up in the tower…



With the whole picture, the player has to decide what to do…

At the end of the confrontation, the wizard does not simply agree to leave. The player picks how to respond, and each path closes some doors and opens others.

Option A: Persuade and Escort (Complete the contract)

The player convinces the wizard to come back by argument, by promising help, or by pointing out what his obsession costs.

Immediate result: Quest Completed, full Ministry reward.

Later consequences:

- The wizard returns to court, but he is only half there.
- The tower is left unattended. The gates keep drifting.
- Zinnia, without her only remaining ally, goes feral and starts appearing outside the tower.

Narrative implication: The player does what was asked and unknowingly abandons the one chance to fix the rupture. A future quest has the Crown's own wizard failing in public.

Option B: Fight or Force Him (The wizard has become dangerous)

The wizard's experiments have endangered the tower and its surroundings. If the player forces him, the confrontation is tense, not heroic: no health bars, only a fight to disarm him and seal the ring.

Immediate result: Quest Completed with reduced reward, or Quest Failed if the player kills him.

Later consequences:

- The Ministry gets its wizard, but the gates are unsealed and unstable.
- The Olara’s trace in the tower fades.

Narrative implication: The player solves the symptom and breaks the person. Echoes in later quests as a grief-stricken court wizard who does not trust adventurers.

Option C: Take the Bargain (Help with one final experiment)

The wizard agrees to return only if the player helps him complete one final experiment. The player carries the artifact into the ring and rotates it while he reopens the passage.

Immediate result: Contract not completed yet, but a hidden path opens.

Later consequences:

- Zinnia is guided home, or the passage opens, and something else comes through. Which happens depends on how the player treated her during the quest (did they ever stop and let her go, or run from her every time?).
- The wizard's spouse may or may not return. The game never confirms it in this quest.

Narrative implication: The most dangerous option, and the one with the largest future hooks. It turns a Bronze escort job into the seed of a much larger quest line.

Summary

Option	Result	Zinnia	Wizard	Hook
A: Persuade	Completed	Feral	Returns, hollow	Court wizard fails publicly
B: Force	Completed (reduced) or Failed	Left behind	Broken	Wizard distrusts adventurers
C: Bargain	Open	Guided home or lost	Hopeful	New questline